



African Languages and Cultures M.A.

Application period: 15 February - 31 March (winter term) and 1 December - 15 January (summer term)

Semester start: October 1st (winter term) and April 1st (summer term)

Language(s) of instruction: English

Introduction

The Master African Languages and Cultures is a two-year research-oriented program with a strong connection to applied issues focusing on theories and methods in linguistics of African languages, language in African cultures and Ethiopian and Eritrean Studies. Graduates with an M.A. in African Languages and Cultures are well prepared for a position in research, education and consulting. By extending language skills in Swahili, Hausa or Amharic, or learning a further African language, you will extend as well your comprehension from local 'doing things with words' to traditional knowledge and philological methods in order to develop your own capacity of working autonomously with primary sources of language data, oral and written history, literatures, cultures, and religions in their relevant context. The language of instruction and examination is English.

The study program envisages an obligatory thematic specialization in one of the following study profiles:

- (1) Applied African Linguistics: Language Education and Language Planning
- (2) Linguistic Analysis and Language Documentation
- (3) Ethiopian and Eritrean Studies
- (4) Language in Culture

Qualification objectives and learning outcomes of the study program

The study profile Applied African Linguistics: Language Education and Language Planning offers advanced courses in all areas of language management, status and corpus planning and the related field of language in education. A strong focus is laid on the aspect of societal multilingualism in Africa and its relevance to the educational sector but as well on the informal educational background of people coming from African countries. Graduates get the right qualifications for Africa related responsible jobs in education, governmental or non-governmental cooperation and international organizations.



The study profile Linguistic Analysis and Language Documentation offers advanced courses in all areas of formal grammar and linguistic field methods. Topics include elicitation, transcription, annotation and analysis of linguistic data from un(der)described African languages. It also covers aspects of documentary linguistics, the production of linguistic-ethnographic records through annotated audio and video data.

The study profile Ethiopian and Eritrean Studies develops and deepens the graduates' knowledge of Ethiopian and Eritrean languages, literatures, cultures and religions. It gives the opportunity to learn the philological method and to apply it to the texts transmitted in manuscripts. The students will be able to analyze texts in Ethiopian and Eritrean languages, both linguistically and philologically, and thus gain insight into such areas of knowledge as history with focus on ancient and premodern history, historical linguistics, religious history of Ethiopia and Eritrea, literature, and manuscript studies. Ethiopian and Eritrean Studies is primarily oriented to the study of linguistics, philology, history, and literature. It considers the oral as well as the manuscript traditions of Ethiopia and Eritrea.

The study profile Language in Culture allows students with a B.A. in African Languages & Cultures or a degree in a similar program to improve their methodological skills and theoretical knowledge in the field of mono- and multilingual communication, language use and knowledge transfer in Africa. Language in culture and communication in African societies are treated from a broad perspective based on the insight that social interaction and collective transmission of knowledge in African cultures can only be comprehended by a deep understanding of language and codifications of verbal interaction. A focus of this study program is laid on communication in multilingual settings and the construction of social meaning in culturally diverse societies. Graduates get the right qualifications for Africa related responsible jobs in the media, education, and in the field of documenting or communicating African cultures.

Admission Requirements

University degree

A bachelor's degree from a German or recognized foreign university in a major subject from African or Semitic studies or related fields.

If you have not received your degree certificate yet, you can submit this by the end of the first semester of your master's program. Please see the "Documents to submit" section below for details.

Additional special admission requirements

Certificate of linguistic knowledge in English at Level B2 (GERS)

Depending on the selected profile, the following admission requirements must be fulfilled:

- Profile Language in Culture:

Proof of competences in African linguistics or African Studies with a minimum of 45 ECTS as well as competences in an African language with a minimum of 16 ECTS (language courses are offered at the institute and a language proficiency equivalent to 16 ECTS can be submitted on request until the end of the second semester). The proof of these competences is usually provided by a Transcript of Records.

- Profile Linguistic Analysis and Language Documentation and Applied African Linguistics:

Proof of fundamental knowledge in phonetics/phonology, morphology and syntax of with a minimum of 45 ECTS as well as competences in an African language with a minimum of 16 ECTS (language proficiency equivalent to 16 ECTS can be submitted on request until the end of the second semester). The proof of these competences is usually provided by a Transcript of Records.

- Profile Ethiopian and Eritrean Studies:

Proof of competence in Semitic, Philological, Christian Oriental or African studies with a minimum of 45 ECTS and basic knowledge of Geez (Ancient Ethiopic) with a minimum of 8 ECTS (language proficiency equivalent to 8 ECTS can be submitted on request until the end of the second semester). The proof of these competences is usually provided by a Transcript of Records.

For details of the legal basis for this regulation, please see the admission bylaws for your chosen degree program: www.uni-hamburg.de/zugang-master

Recognition of transcripts for degree programs completed at foreign higher education institutions

If you obtained your first degree abroad, your certificate will be reviewed during the application procedure in the faculty of your program.

If your degree certificate is not in English or German, please include a copy of a certified English or German translation of the certificate with your application documents.



Application

Online Application

You will need to complete the online application available on Universität Hamburg's application portal during the application period: www.uni-hamburg.de/online-application

Please create a user account, enter your information online, and submit your application online.

You will then need to print your online application as a PDF document and submit it together with the following documents to the email address or contact indicated below.

Documents to submit

Please submit uncertified copies of all documents. For documents not issued in German or English, a certified German translation is required.

- PDF of your online application
- Degree certificate or provisional Transcript of Records
If you are still studying when you apply and cannot yet provide a final certificate containing your grades, please submit your current Transcript of Records confirming your provisional grade point average. You will then need to submit your degree certificate by the end of the first semester of your master's program.
- Transcript of Records
- Curriculum vitae
- short statement of purpose, in which you justify your choice of specialization.
- All applicants must provide evidence for proficiency in English (equivalent to B2 level of the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR)), which can as well be obtained at the language center of Hamburg University; English native speakers don't need B2 evidence.
- Where applicable required additional language certificates of African languages (if not documented in the TOR).



Application address

Online application (documents as PDF), subject "M.A.-Application": afrikanistik.aai@uni-hamburg.de

Submission of documents by post:

(NOTE that you DO NOT NEED to submit paper documents)

Universität Hamburg

Asien-Afrika-Institut

Abteilung für Afrikanistik und Äthiopistik

M.A – Application

Edmund-Siemers-Allee 1

20146 Hamburg, Germany

(At the same address — Department of African Linguistics and Ethiopian Studies — a publicly accessible mailbox is available.)

Please note that your application can only be considered if your complete application documents reach the application address by the application deadline. This deadline is final; no extensions can be granted.

If you want to submit an additional special application (e.g., hardship application), you will need to send this special application directly via the online application form together with the required proofs as an upload by the application deadline. For more information on special applications, please see www.uni-hamburg.de/sonderantrag and www.uni-hamburg.de/info-master

Admission and enrollment

Once your application has been reviewed, an acceptance or rejection letter will be made available in your STiNE account under the Dokumente (Documents) tab. Please see the information at www.uni-hamburg.de/online-application. An enrollment deadline will be indicated in your acceptance letter - please submit the documents required for enrollment by this date. The enrollment process is an online process. Detailed information about the enrollment process is provided at www.uni-hamburg.de/masterenrollment

<https://www.aai.uni-hamburg.de/studium/master/52-afrika-ma.html>



Universität Hamburg

DER FORSCHUNG | DER LEHRE | DER BILDUNG

FAKULTÄT
FÜR GEISTESWISSENSCHAFTEN

Contact

Universität Hamburg
Asien-Afrika-Institut
Abteilung für Afrikanistik und Äthiopistik
Edmund-Siemers-Allee 1
20146 Hamburg, Germany

E-Mail: afrikanistik.aai@uni-hamburg.de

Last updated: January 2026